

Beyond Urgency: From Practitioner to Scholar

Doctoral Portfolio

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Introduction

Advanced academic programming often looks equitable on paper. Enrollment numbers go up. Course offerings expand. Districts announce rising participation rates. But access alone does not produce intellectual equity. In my work supporting Advanced Placement instruction across Fort Worth Independent School District (FWISD), I have watched the same course play out very differently across campuses. In one Title I, lower-resourced classroom, students were filling out structured note guides, prepping for multiple-choice practice, and defining vocabulary words out of context. In a higher-SES, better-resourced campus running the same course, students were doing peer critique, keeping metacognitive reflection journals, and iterating on analytical writing. Both classrooms were on pace. Both were aligned to standards. The cognitive work required of students was not even close to the same.

I came into this program convinced I had identified the problem and was prepared to fix it. Reality had other ideas. Over two years of coursework, research, collaboration, and reflection, I began to think differently about the problem itself. I still feel the urgency I started with, but I have learned to slow down long enough to ask better questions. That shift runs through this portfolio.

The pattern I had been watching across FWISD campuses went deeper than logistics. Pacing guides were aligned, resources were distributed, and teachers were credentialed. The real difference was in the instructional design and the assumptions teachers made about what students were capable of doing. I knew that difference mattered when I entered the program. Now I have the theoretical language, empirical literature, and conceptual framework to explain why it matters and to design research that can test what I have observed. The rest of this portfolio documents that development. The companion portfolio website at <https://melissaablythe->

star.github.io/doctoralportfolioMAB houses all fifteen appendices as downloadable artifacts, organized to mirror the rubric structure of this paper.

This portfolio documents the development of my identity as a scholar-practitioner. The sections that follow address each element of the Marshall University Doctoral Portfolio Rubric: Collaboration, Depth of Understanding, Reflection, Scholarship, Communication, and Research. Each section includes the artifacts that support it and closes with a summary statement tied directly to the rubric language.

Collaboration

Before this program, collaboration meant coordination to me: aligning efforts, sharing resources, and getting the work done efficiently. During the program, it became shared inquiry. I began to see collaboration as a way to generate knowledge about practice with other people. That understanding has changed how I lead, coach teachers, and design research.

Faculty Collaboration

Working with Dr. Childress on my conceptual framework and NSSA conference presentation required a level of precision I had not previously applied to my thinking. When I brought an early draft for review, the question came back: where is the mechanism? I had assembled theories I valued. I had run a pilot study with interesting results. What I needed to do was show, from a synthesis or theoretical perspective, how one thing produces another. That challenge forced substantive revision and elevated the work from observation to argument.

Dr. Childress has consistently pushed me to boil things down rather than speak in the broad, meta terms that come naturally to me. I tend to think and write at the level of systems and structures, and he brings me back to the specific, the granular, and the defensible. That push has strengthened every piece of work I have produced, and it has made me a more disciplined

thinker, better able to explain why a claim holds up under scrutiny rather than only asserting that it does. Co-presenting at the National Social Science Association Fall Conference in October 2025 required that same discipline in front of an academic audience with zero prior context for my work and no obligation to be generous with their questions (see Appendix L).

Coursework with Dr. Yuan produced my Positionality Reflection (see Appendix G), Conceptual Framework (see Appendix F), Pilot Study (see Appendix A), and Teaching Philosophy paper on equity and excellence in advanced academics (see Appendix M), all of which required defending theoretical choices rather than simply reporting them. The Teaching Philosophy paper was an early attempt to put my pedagogical commitments on paper in a way that engaged Freire and hooks directly rather than gesturing toward them, and it now reads as the first articulated version of the equity and metacognition argument that runs through everything I have written since.

The Positionality Reflection was particularly significant and, honestly, the assignment I did not expect to matter as much as it did. I had always spoken broadly about equity and access in advanced coursework. I knew the problem because I had lived professionally adjacent to it for years. But where I needed to go deeper was in defining the scholarly precision or ground my claims in research and move beyond my observations and instinct, and that assignment really drove the shift. It moved me from advocacy language into research language, and in doing so it clarified something I had been circling without landing on: the argument was never really about who gets into AP courses. In truth, it was about what happens to students once they are inside them, whether they are given access to the kind of thinking those courses demand or simply placed in proximity to it. That distinction became the foundation for everything that followed, including the pilot study and the dissertation trajectory I am now pursuing.

Coursework with Dr. Sochor was early in the program and served a different but equally important purpose. At that stage, I was finding my footing again as a scholar after years of operating primarily as a practitioner and leader. The three annotated bibliographies (see Appendix H) examining AP equity, dual enrollment, gifted education, and the experiences of underrepresented students in advanced academic settings were the first sustained academic reading I had done in a long time that was directly connected to my professional world. I was not reading theory for its own sake. I was reading Kyburg, Hertberg-Davis, and Callahan (2007) on talented minorities in AP programs and seeing my own campuses in the data. I was reading Saffore on Black girls' postsecondary outcomes and recognizing patterns I had observed for years without the language to name them. That work gave me both the literature base I needed and something harder to quantify: confidence that my questions were legitimate, that the field had been asking versions of them too, and that I had something real to contribute to that conversation.

Peer Collaboration

Presenting at the SITE conference brought together five doctoral students from different professional contexts, including Steve Geddis, Tiffany Clemmins, Becky Osterfeld, Linda Rich, and myself, to build a cohesive argument about AI and teacher preparation (see Appendix K). Our perspectives did not always align at the start, and getting to a coherent argument took real negotiation. Prior to SITE, I also collaborated with faculty on the development of graduate-level AI course modules, including work on Natural Language Processing and student use of AI tools in learning (see Appendix O). Contributing to course development at the graduate level meant synthesizing emerging research on AI and cognition with practical instructional design, and it deepened my understanding of how AI tools can support or undermine metacognitive

development depending on how they are positioned within instruction. Coursework-related peer critique during pilot study development helped me catch leading questions in my interview protocol. A colleague pointed out that the framing may have implied deficit in students rather than in instructional design. That observation reshaped how I write about equity in research contexts, and the change carried forward into the dissertation proposal and the NSSA presentation.

Beyond formal collaboration, I have worked closely with a small group of fellow doctoral students every week for the past three years. Tiffany Clemmins, Becky Osterfeld, and I have met over Teams almost weekly across the program. In those meetings we talk through coursework and projects, give each other feedback, and frankly just keep each other going through kind words, a lot of laughs, and steady encouragement. Aaron Jones is part of that circle too. He and I message and text often about whatever piece of writing or thinking either of us is wrestling with. We run major project ideas by each other and trade honest feedback. Linda Rich has read my work as well, and her feedback has consistently sharpened both the arguments and the evidence. With Steve Geddis, I text about courses and what is happening in them. He has a way of cutting through whenever I am overcomplicating something, which I do more often than I would like to admit. What started as academic collaboration developed into friendship over the course of the program. We text about school and about life, and we send each other memes when one of us needs the lift. I expect those relationships to outlast the program itself, and we have all said we hope to graduate close enough together to celebrate as a group. Those relationships are not incidental to the doctoral experience. They are part of what made the experience possible.

Practitioner Partnership

The action research at Dunbar High School began with a teacher's question. He had fifteen capable AP U.S. Government students who were enrolled and showing up, but they were not using the AP Classroom platform in ways that produced much learning. He knew something had to shift and was honest that he did not know what. That uncertainty, said out loud in our first planning conversation, became the foundation of the partnership. It also changed what I thought I was there to do. I came in ready to investigate the question with him. Over three weeks, we ran a structured cycle of co-planning, modeling, observation, and debrief (see Appendix B).

shared, and decided together how we would know if it worked. I modeled the move in his classroom, watched him run variations of it with his students, and met with him at the end of the week to talk through what the data showed. We used pre and post AP Classroom progress checks, weekly observation notes using a structured engagement and metacognition checklist (see Appendix C), student metacognitive exit tickets (see Appendix D), weekly teacher reflections, and a researcher coaching log. The full cycle is documented in the action research final presentation (see Appendix J), and the score data lives in the AP Classroom Progress-Check tracker (see Appendix E).

The student outcomes were real. Individual gains on AP Classroom progress checks ran from 32 to 50 percentage points, with the class average moving from around 40 percent at baseline to around 80 percent post-intervention. Every student finished the post-assessment, which mattered because at baseline several of them had been leaving items blank. The exit tickets told the more important story. Early in the cycle, their responses were short and vague. By the end they were writing about which specific strategies they used, why those strategies helped, and what they would do differently next time. That move from unspecific to strategy-

based language is what Schraw and Dennison (1994) describe as students shifting from absent to emerging metacognitive awareness, and it happened inside three weeks.

The teacher changed too, and that change is what I keep coming back to. His weekly reflections track a real shift in his questioning. Early on he described himself as confirming right answers and redirecting wrong ones. By the third week he was telling me he had caught himself mid-lesson and changed a question because he heard the deficit framing in his own voice. That is Schön's (1983) reflection-in-action happening inside a real Title I AP classroom, produced not by a workshop but by sustained inquiry inside his own practice with someone he trusted to be honest with him. The coaching log shows when the partnership became collaborative. By the second week he was bringing me his own questions about specific students before I had a chance to ask, and that shift, when the person being coached starts leading the conversation, is now the marker I use to distinguish coaching from shared inquiry.

Beyond the data, this partnership taught me something theory alone could not: sustainable instructional improvement requires relational trust, and trust requires honesty about what is working and what is not (Joyce and Showers, 2002). The working structure we built helped the teacher see his own practice clearly enough to make different decisions. Co-planning grounded in research, live modeling, structured observation, honest debrief, and room for both of us to push back created that structure. I am carrying this model into the dissertation because it treats teachers as partners in the research.

Summary: Collaboration is documented across faculty partnerships with Dr. Childress, Dr. Yuan, and Dr. Sochor; peer collaboration on conference panels and protocol development; and a sustained practitioner research partnership at Dunbar High School. Each experience produced scholarship rather than only activity. Artifacts: NSSA conference presentation, SITE

conference presentation, annotated bibliographies (C-701), action research plan, conceptual framework (EDF 725), positionality reflection (CI 704), teaching philosophy on equity and excellence (CI 704), graduate-level AI course modules.

Depth of Understanding

I came into this program already convinced that the problem in advanced academics was philosophical, not logistical. What I had watched across FWISD campuses, the same course producing different cognitive work for different students, was not going to be solved by aligning pacing guides or distributing better resources. I had the conviction and passion, but what I needed was the theoretical vocabulary to defend it under scrutiny, the empirical literature to ground it, or the conceptual architecture to do something rigorous with it. Those gaps are what the program filled.

My core beliefs have remained steady across these three years, but my understanding of them has deepened. I can now explain the philosophical commitments behind a position, build a theoretical framework, and design research grounded in that framework. Earlier in my career, I often relied on instinct and professional experience. Those still matter, but I now know how to place them in conversation with theory and evidence. That growth shows up across the annotated bibliographies, the technology paper, the curriculum theory paper, and the conceptual framework that ties the work together.

Curriculum Theory

Eisner (2002) reframed curriculum as an intellectual and aesthetic encounter rather than content to be delivered. I initially read that as an aesthetic flourish; the kind of language curriculum theorists use to make instructional design sound more elevated than it is. What I came to understand is that Eisner is making a political claim about what counts as intellectual work

and whose minds are presumed capable of doing it. When AP instruction in a Title I classroom reduces to definition lists and multiple-choice practice while the same course at a higher-SES campus runs peer critique and analytical revision, Eisner's question becomes uncomfortable: what is the curriculum implicitly saying about whose intellect is worth cultivating?

Freire (1970) makes the political claim explicit. His pedagogy of critical consciousness asks whose knowledge gets centered and who decides what rigor looks like. In AP classrooms serving Title I students, those questions are not abstract. They explain specific patterns I had been watching for years without language to name. My CI 702 curriculum theory paper (see Appendix N) integrates Eisner's aesthetic framework with Freire's critical pedagogy into a personal theory of curriculum that positions advanced academics as both an artistic and political space. That synthesis has become foundational to how I think about equity and rigor in AP classrooms, and it is the earliest articulation of the argument that runs through the rest of the portfolio.

Critical Pedagogy and Liberatory Practice

Freire (1970) is foundational to how I understand what advanced academics is supposed to do. Pedagogy of the Oppressed makes an argument that no curriculum framework grounded only in cognitive science can make on its own: education is either a practice of domestication or a practice of liberation, and there is no neutral middle. The questions Freire raises about whose knowledge counts as rigorous, whose ways of reasoning get validated as academic, and whose voices get treated as authoritative are the questions Title I AP classrooms answer every day, mostly without realizing they are answering them.

Freire's (1970) concept of conscientização, critical consciousness, is what keeps my work on metacognition from collapsing into a technical training problem. Metacognitive instruction in

Title I AP classrooms is not about teaching students to monitor their thinking in the abstract. It is about giving them tools to claim intellectual authority in spaces that have historically denied it to students who look like them. hooks (1994) extends this through her insistence that education as the practice of freedom requires the teacher to take students' lives, identities, and intellectual capacity seriously, not as something to be accommodated around the curriculum but as the foundation the curriculum is built on. Freire and hooks are why my argument about equity in advanced academics goes beyond access or instructional design to what education is for, who it is for, and what is at stake when the answers to those questions go unexamined.

Cognitive and Learning Theory

Vygotsky (1978) explained how higher-order reasoning develops through guided participation rather than independent discovery. That matters for AP instruction because it means students do not arrive with thinking skills fully formed. Those skills are built through deliberate instructional design, or they are not built at all. Flavell's (1979) distinction between metacognitive knowledge and metacognitive regulation gave me a framework for what I was already observing: students often knew they were struggling without knowing what to do about it. They had the knowledge piece. They lacked the regulation piece, and no one was explicitly teaching it. Schön's (1983, p. 49) reflection-in-action put the responsibility back on teachers. When teachers make their own reasoning visible in real time, students gain access to a model of what thinking through complexity looks like.

The synthesis that took longer to recognize is that Freire's conscientização and Flavell's metacognitive regulation are doing related work from very different traditions. Flavell (1979) describes a cognitive capacity. Freire (1970) describes a political one. In a Title I AP classroom, those two capacities are inseparable. A student who can monitor and regulate their own thinking

gains the intellectual authority Freire is talking about. My conceptual framework treats these as connected on purpose because in practice they are connected, even though the literatures rarely speak to each other.

Culturally Responsive Pedagogy

Hammond (2015) connects culturally responsive teaching directly to cognitive development, which made her work usable in my framework rather than parallel to it. Her argument that culturally responsive instruction supports neural pathways for higher-order thinking gives equity arguments the empirical grounding they often lack. Additionally, it explains mechanistically why deficit framing in Title I AP classrooms produces the cognitive outcomes it produces. Zimmerman's (2002) self-regulated learning model extends the metacognitive thread into agency. Self-regulation is not just a skill students apply during a task. It is how they come to see themselves as capable of directing their own intellectual work, which is the developmental outcome equity-focused AP instruction should be designed to produce. Neither Hammond nor Zimmerman functions as an add-on to the framework. Both carry big weight and removing either would collapse the argument connecting cognitive science to equity.

Literature Engagement and Field Knowledge

Three annotated bibliographies completed in C-701 with Dr. Sochor (see Appendix H) document sustained engagement with the research base on AP equity, dual enrollment, gifted education, and the experiences of first-generation students and Black students in advanced academic settings. This reading confirmed what my classroom observations suggested: programs designed for rigor frequently reproduce the inequities they claim to address. Kyburg, Hertberg-Davis, and Callahan (2007) on AP programs and talented minorities and Saffore (2023) on Black girls' postsecondary outcomes both show that access without intentional instructional support produces

uneven results. Dixon's (2020) argument for reframing gifted education toward maximizing learning for all students rather than labeling some as capable connected directly to my developing framework around metacognition as infrastructure rather than enrichment.

Technology, AI, and Cognition

My CIEC 700 paper (see Appendix I) was the first place I put the AI question on paper, and it remains the theoretical foundation for the dissertation argument I am developing. The paper examined smart learning environments, clicker technology, learning logs, flipped classrooms, and AI tools through a metacognitive development lens. I focused on when technology helps students learn, how it helps, and the conditions under which it can shut down deeper thinking. Conversations about AI in classrooms often reduce it to a productivity tool or a threat. My framework asks a more useful question: does the technology create space for students to do their own metacognitive work, or does it do that work for them?

That argument became the foundation for my SITE conference contribution on AI and teacher preparation, and it extended further through my work on graduate-level AI course modules, including content on Natural Language Processing and student use of AI tools in learning (see Appendix O). Contributing to course development at that level required synthesizing emerging research on AI and cognition with practical instructional design, and it sharpened the position I am now bringing into the dissertation: AI tools, designed and deployed deliberately, can function as a mediator for metacognitive development in Title I AP classrooms. This is a theoretical claim the dissertation is designed to test, and it sits at the center of where my framework is heading.

Conceptual Framework

My Conceptual Framework (see Appendix F), developed in EDF 725 with Dr. Yuan, synthesized these theoretical strands into a working model. Teacher perception mediates instructional design. Instructional design shapes metacognitive opportunity. Metacognitive opportunity influences student agency. In this model, equity and rigor are not competing priorities. They become mutually reinforcing when instruction is explicitly designed to build students' capacity to regulate their own learning. This framework is not a list of theorists I admire but a structure I can defend, apply, and build on in dissertation research.

The framework did not arrive fully formed. Its curriculum theory grounding came earlier, in CI 702, where I integrated Eisner's aesthetic theory with Freire's critical pedagogy into a personal theory of curriculum (see Appendix N). The metacognition and equity strands developed across coursework with Dr. Yuan and field-based research at Dunbar. The AI thread emerged from the CIEC 700 paper and was sharpened through the SITE conference work. When I designed the pilot study interview protocol, the framework told me what to look for, which ultimately went beyond what teachers reported about their practice to what their language about students revealed about the cognitive/learning opportunities they were willing to design. That theoretical depth has methodological consequences. It shaped my decision to use phenomenology for the pilot rather than a survey design, and it will shape the dissertation's test of whether targeted intervention at the teacher-perception level produces measurable shifts at the student-agency level.

Summary: Depth of understanding is demonstrated through sustained theoretical synthesis across curriculum theory, critical pedagogy, cognitive science, culturally responsive pedagogy, and the emerging intersection of AI and cognition. The framework is not a collection of admired theorists. It is an architecture built deliberately, with each strand chosen for the

work it does in explaining why the same AP course produces different cognitive outcomes for different students, and what instruction would have to look like to change that. Artifacts: Conceptual Framework (EDF 725), CI 702 Curriculum Theory Paper, Annotated Bibliographies 1, 2, and 3 (C-701), CIEC 700 Technology Paper, graduate-level AI course modules.

Reflection

The rubric describes outstanding reflection as in-depth synthesis connecting doctoral experiences with professional growth. For me, that has been the most personal and uncomfortable part of the program. Examining the assumptions I brought with me was hard work, and it mattered as much as the coursework itself.

Reflection in this program operated at three scales for me. The first was reflection on self: who I am, what I bring, and what blind spots my identity creates in equity work. The second was reflection on research practice: the discipline of catching my own assumptions in how I framed questions and read data. The third was watching reflection happen in someone else's practice in real time, inside the action research at Dunbar. Each scale taught me something different about what reflective practice requires, and together they form the foundation of the reflexive research stance I bring into the dissertation.

Positionality and Identity

My Positionality Reflection (see Appendix G), written for CI 704 with Dr. Yuan, was the first assignment that made me examine where my commitments came from. I am the first college graduate on both sides of my extended family. I grew up in a conservative, working-class household without access to advanced coursework. Those experiences created the urgency I brought into this work, and they also created blind spots. Writing the reflection forced me to name my savior complex, the assumptions I made about what underserved students needed, and

my impatience with slow systemic change. All of those things were getting in the way of genuine equity work. I also had to confront the privilege embedded in my own advocacy and accept that advocacy rooted in an unexamined identity can become more about the advocate than the people it claims to serve.

The reflection also required engaging with Crenshaw's (1989) intersectionality, hooks' (1994) pedagogy as freedom, and Paris' (2012) culturally sustaining pedagogy in direct relationship to my own biography, not just as abstract frameworks. That kind of theoretical application is different from citation. It is the integration of scholarship into self-understanding.

Reflexivity in Research

Early drafts of my pilot study (see Appendix A) interview protocol revealed something surprising and slightly uncomfortable. One of my questions asked teachers, “How do you perceive the abilities of your AP students, especially those from marginalized populations?” The question was supposed to surface deficit thinking. What it did was prime it. By naming marginalized populations inside the question about ability, I had built a comparison into the protocol that a teacher may not have been making on their own. The teacher who would have described all of their students' abilities in unified terms was now structurally directed toward differentiating by race and class. I was preparing to study how deficit framing operates in AP classrooms using a protocol that produced deficit framing on contact. Faculty feedback pushed me to revise the question into something more neutral, asking teachers instead to describe their students as learners, and to let any comparisons surface in their own language rather than being prompted by mine. The revision itself was small in word count, but what it taught me about my own thinking was substantial, and the discipline of catching bias in my own instrument design is now a habit I bring into every research protocol I write.

Reflection in Practice

The action research cycle produced a third kind of reflection, one that differed from both the positionality work and the protocol revision. This was reflection happening in real time, in front of me, in someone else's practice. Partway through the three weeks, the AP Government teacher I was working with told me he had started hearing himself ask what rather than how during class, and that he had caught it in the moment and changed the question. That was Schön's (1983) reflection-in-action happening in a real classroom. Watching it happen confirmed something the literature had told me but I had not seen up close, which is that the most meaningful learning often happens while a practitioner is still inside the experience rather than after processing it from a safe distance. It also confirmed that the research was not only accurate but observable in the kind of school where literature predicts these shifts would be hardest to produce.

What I took from that moment was not simply confirmation of Schön but a more specific claim: reflection-in-action does not happen in isolation. The teacher caught his own question because we had built a structure around his practice that made his thinking visible to him in real time. The coaching cycle, the weekly debrief, and the structured observation were all doing work on the teacher's reflective capacity that he could not have done alone. That design principle is now central to the dissertation. Studying metacognitive instruction in Title I AP classrooms requires not only observing what teachers do but building the conditions under which their reflective practice becomes possible to study. The dissertation is built around that recognition.

Summary: Reflection in this portfolio is not retrospective decoration. It is embedded in the research process itself, from the positionality work that named unexamined assumptions, to the protocol revision that corrected researcher bias, to real-time reflection during the action

research cycle. The program produced a measurable shift in how I understand my role: from a leader who solves problems to a scholar-practitioner who studies them. Artifacts: Positionality Reflection (CI 704), pilot study reflexivity and ethics sections, action research final presentation.

Scholarship and Communication

The portfolio requirement specifies at least one co-authored conference presentation or publication in collaboration with a faculty member. My NSSA conference presentation (see Appendix L) meets that requirement directly. In October 2025, I co-authored and co-presented 'Teacher Use of Metacognitive Practices in AP Classrooms' with Dr. Ron Childress at the National Social Science Association Fall Conference, presenting virtually to the conference held in Hot Springs, Arkansas. The presentation laid the conceptual groundwork for a larger study of how teachers use metacognitive strategies in advanced secondary courses, covering what metacognition is, how students develop it, what gets in the way, and what it means for teacher preparation and policy.

The sections that follow trace how my scholarly work developed across the program. The committee is evaluating the scholarship I produced and the growth that occurred while I was producing it.

Development Over Time

Three annotated bibliographies in C-701 (Fall 2023; see Appendix H) represent the first systematic engagement with the research base on AP equity and advanced academics. Rather than functioning as summaries, each entry required critical evaluation of the methodology, theoretical grounding, and relevance of each source to the field. My CIEC 700 technology paper (Fall 2023; see Appendix I) was the first extended scholarly argument I produced in the program, moving from literature synthesis to original claim.

The pilot study (EDF 625, Summer 2024; see Appendix A) was the first original empirical work. Designing the study, collecting data, coding transcripts, and translating findings into defensible claims required methodological discipline that reading alone cannot produce. The Conceptual Framework (EDF 725, Fall 2024; see Appendix F) required building a theoretical architecture rather than borrowing one, connecting established frameworks to a specific problem of practice in a way that could ground future research.

The SITE conference (March 2025) extended this work into a national scholarly conversation. My section argued that AI is not reducing the cognitive demands placed on students but increasing them, because students are now required to evaluate, interpret, and revise AI-generated content in addition to producing their own. That argument drew directly from my theoretical grounding in metacognition and is supported by the literature reviewed in my CIEC 700 paper. The NSSA conference (October 2025) put the conceptual foundation of my research in front of a national academic audience and required me to defend my thinking and respond to critique in real time.

Communication

The rubric defines outstanding communication as clear, fluent, and effective presentation across a range of experiences, with self-confidence and awareness of audience. My communication has developed through written scholarship, oral presentations, and research instrument design. Early in the program, I tried to include everything because I wanted the reader to know I had done the work. My later writing is more precise. I state what I found, build an argument, and write with a reader's likely questions in mind. The NSSA and SITE presentations required very different approaches. At NSSA, I translated the research on metacognition for an academic audience with little context for the AP world. At SITE, I worked with a room that held

sharply different views on AI in education, from deep skepticism to uncritical enthusiasm. Both experiences required me to read the room, adjust in the moment, and stay grounded in the evidence when the questions became pointed.

Summary: The required scholarship element is met through the NSSA co-presentation with Dr. Childress. Additional scholarship is demonstrated through the SITE conference panel, pilot study, conceptual framework, annotated bibliographies, CIEC 700 paper, and action research. Communication is demonstrated through written research artifacts showing measurable growth in argumentation, two national conference presentations requiring different audience adaptations, and research instrument design that translates theoretical constructs into observable indicators. Artifacts: NSSA presentation, SITE presentation, pilot study, conceptual framework, annotated bibliographies, CIEC 700 paper, action research presentation.

Research

The research I conducted across this program was driven by one question, asked in two different ways. Across Fort Worth ISD, the same Advanced Placement course was producing different cognitive work for students in different schools. Students in better-resourced campuses were doing peer critique, keeping reflection journals, and revising analytical writing. In contrast, students in Title I campuses, sitting in the same course on paper, were filling out structured note guides and defining vocabulary out of context. The course was the same on both campuses, but the cognitive demand placed on students was not. That gap is what I came into the program wanting to understand, and it shaped the research I designed across the next three years (see Appendix A for the pilot study and Appendix B for the action research plan).

The pilot study (EDF 625) was qualitative and phenomenological, designed to surface how teachers in those two settings described their students and their own instructional decisions. I chose phenomenology because the question I was asking was not how often metacognitive instruction occurred, but what teachers were thinking when they decided whether to offer it. That was a question about meaning, not frequency, and meaning is what phenomenological methods are built to access. The study did what it was designed to do. However, it also revealed the limits of what one researcher with two interviews could claim. Faculty feedback was right that the scope was ambitious, that the IRB considerations needed tighter management, and that the analytical claims would benefit from a second coder. Those are the lessons a pilot study is supposed to teach, and they are the ones now built into the dissertation design.

The action research at Dunbar High School took a different methodological turn (see Appendix B). After the pilot identified teacher perception as a mechanism, I wanted to know what happened when that mechanism was directly addressed. Phenomenology could not answer that question. Action research could. I designed a three-week coaching intervention with one AP U.S. Government teacher, pre and post measures of student performance, structured observation, and weekly reflective debriefs. The action research was not a continuation of the pilot in either methods or scale but a deliberate methodological shift, driven by what the pilot had taught me about what phenomenology could and could not answer. Together, the two studies form a coherent line of inquiry rather than two adjacent projects, with the pilot identifying the mechanism and the action research testing what happens when it is directly interrupted through coaching. The dissertation is built to extend both, with a methodology I have deliberately chosen rather than inherited.

Pilot Study: Teacher Perception and Metacognition

Conducted in EDF 625, the pilot study (see Appendix A) was titled 'Teacher Metacognitive Practices in Advanced Academic Courses: A Look at Bias and Perception.' I used a phenomenological design, interviewing and observing two AP teachers, Mr. B and Mr. C, who were teaching summer AP bootcamps at two FWISD campuses, and I coded the data thematically following Saldana (2011). The difference between their classrooms was hard to miss. Mr. B ran Socratic seminars and had students keep reflective journals, and his students pushed back on each other's thinking. Mr. C's students, on the other hand, wrote short, surface-level reflections and needed frequent reminders to stay on task. When I asked Mr. C about his students, he said, "I think they all have potential, but some face more challenges than others." Later, he added, "It's tough when you know they're dealing with so much outside of school. It's hard to get them to focus on metacognition" (Interview Transcript #1). On its face, that sounds like compassion. However, it also meant his students were asked to do less of the very thinking AP courses are supposed to build.

The problem was not student capacity. It was instructional expectation. That finding, which was grounded in participant language and supported by the existing literature on teacher bias and AP equity, became the central claim driving the dissertation proposal. Faculty feedback correctly identified that the scope was ambitious and that a full-scale study would require more tightly delimited research questions and more carefully managed IRB considerations. Both of those observations are now built into the dissertation design.

Action Research: Dunbar High School, FWISD

The action research project (see Appendix B) applied inquiry to a specific instructional problem in a specific classroom. The research question was: How does coaching an AP U.S.

Government and Politics teacher to use AP Classroom collaboratively affect student engagement and metacognitive thinking over a three-week period? The study took place at Dunbar High School in FWISD, with one AP Government teacher and fifteen students. My role was dual in that I served as both researcher and instructional coach. I modeled one collaborative AP Classroom lesson, co-planned weekly lessons, observed one class period per week using a structured engagement and metacognition checklist (see Appendix C), and facilitated weekly reflective coaching conversations.

Data collection included AP Classroom pre and post-test scores (see Appendix E), weekly classroom observation notes, student metacognitive exit tickets administered after each collaborative lesson (see Appendix D), weekly teacher reflections, and a researcher coaching log. The results were clear. Pre-test scores ranged from 30 to 47 percent. Post-test scores ranged from 72 to 95 percent, with individual student growth between 32 and 50 percent. Every student completed the post-assessment, a shift from baseline where several left questions unanswered.

The observation notes documented a clear shift in classroom dynamics across three weeks. Peer interaction increased. Students began explaining their reasoning aloud without being prompted. Exit ticket responses evolved from brief and unspecific to strategy-based, with students identifying what helped them, explaining why, and naming what they would do differently next time. The teacher documented increasing intentionality in his questioning, moving from confirming correct answers to asking students to justify their reasoning. Findings aligned with research on metacognitive prompting and the impact of coaching with live modeling on instructional practice (Joyce and Showers, 2002).

Together, these two research experiences established a clear and defensible research direction. The pilot study revealed the mechanism: teacher perception operating through

instructional design to shape metacognitive opportunity. The action research demonstrated what changes when that mechanism is directly interrupted through coaching. The dissertation will build on both, with a more precisely designed methodology and a longer data collection timeline.

Summary: Two original research studies, each designed and carried out from research question through findings. The pilot study produced qualitative findings on teacher perception and metacognitive practice across SES contexts. The action research documented measurable student growth through a theoretically grounded intervention. Both are organized, thorough, and directly inform the dissertation. Artifacts: pilot study full paper, action research plan, observation checklist, student exit tickets, AP Classroom data tracker, action research final presentation.

Integration of Learning and Future Directions

The courses in this program were distinct in their subject matter, but the intellectual threads running through them were not. Those threads emerged with a consistency I did not initially recognize. Metacognition, teacher belief, instructional design, equity in advanced academics, and the relationship between what we think students can do and what we actually give them the chance to do appeared across curriculum theory, qualitative methods, action research, the technology paper, both conference presentations, and the positionality reflection. In truth, that consistency was not planned. It reflects a genuine line of inquiry the program helped me recognize and pursue with increasing rigor.

My Area of Emphasis (AoE) in research in Curriculum and Instruction integrates directly and consistently with this line of inquiry. Understanding curriculum as more than content, as an encounter shaped by teacher belief, design choices, and student identity, is the conceptual heart

of everything I have studied. The AoE has not been a separate track from my research interests but the foundation on which those interests were built.

The dissertation I am preparing will examine how teacher perceptions of student capacity influence the design and delivery of metacognitive instruction in AP classrooms, with particular attention to how these patterns differ across socioeconomic school contexts and how AI tools might be positioned to support more equitable metacognitive development. The pilot study (Appendix A) provided preliminary evidence and methodological lessons. The action research (Appendices B–E, J) demonstrated what changes when instructional design is deliberately shifted. The conceptual framework (Appendix F) provides theoretical architecture. The annotated bibliographies (Appendix H) document the existing literature base. The NSSA presentation (Appendix L) placed the conceptual foundation of this work before a scholarly audience and invited critique. I am ready to design a study that is more tightly focused, more fully resourced, and more carefully managed than either prior study, because those studies taught me what that requires.

Summary Reflection

The Marshall University doctoral portfolio asks whether the candidate is ready: ready for candidacy, ready to design and complete a dissertation, and ready to contribute to the field. This portfolio is my answer to that question.

I have completed every required artifact, but completion alone is a small part of the answer. Producing the work changed how I think. The collaborations, coursework, pilot study, action research, conference presentations, and positionality work all contributed to the development of my scholarly identity. Faculty mentorship taught me to identify and defend a mechanism. Peer collaboration exposed assumptions inside my framing of equity. The action

research at Dunbar showed me how relational trust and structured inquiry support genuine instructional change. The pilot study taught me what one researcher with two interviews can responsibly claim, which is exactly what a pilot is supposed to teach.

I entered this program focused on solving the problems in front of me. I leave it committed to studying those same problems more carefully because careful study offers a stronger path toward lasting change in the classrooms I care about. The dissertation is the next step in a line of inquiry already underway. It is grounded in a methodology I chose deliberately, a theoretical framework I can defend, and a research stance already tested in the field.

I am ready.

Acknowledgment of AI Use

I used Anthropic's Claude (Opus 4.7) as a proofreading assistant and thought partner during the final development of this portfolio. Claude supported proofreading and served as a thought partner for identifying potential gaps in argument and evidence. Both Claude and Grammarly were used to offer proofreading/grammar support on paragraph and sentence-level writing. All research, theoretical claims, and scholarly contributions in this portfolio are my own (Anthropic, 2026; Grammarly, 2026).

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Appendices

Appendix A: Pilot Study

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2024). Teacher Metacognitive Practices in Advanced Academic Courses: A Look at Bias and Perception. EDF 625: Qualitative Research, Marshall University. Full paper including introduction, literature review, methods, results, discussion, interview protocol, and codebook.

Appendix B: Action Research Plan

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2025). Collaborative AP Classroom Use to Boost Engagement and Metacognition. Dunbar High School, FWISD. Research question, participant information, three-week data collection timeline, validity procedures, and ethical considerations.

Appendix C: Engagement and Metacognition Observation Checklist

Tool 2 used during all three action research classroom observations. Structured one-page checklist with indicators for student collaboration, peer questioning, reasoning articulation, teacher metacognitive prompting, and on-task engagement.

Appendix D: Student Exit Ticket

Tool 3 administered after each collaborative AP Classroom lesson. Three-question protocol addressing strategy use, impact of collaboration on understanding, and next steps for improvement.

Appendix E: AP Classroom Progress-Check Data Tracker

Pre- and post-test score data for all fifteen student participants. Individual student growth ranging from 32 to 50 percentage points. Average pre-test score approximately 40%; average post-test score approximately 80%. Post-intervention completion rate: 100%.

Appendix F: Conceptual Framework

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2024). Conceptual Framework for Investigating Metacognition in AP Classrooms. EDF 725: Advanced Qualitative Research, Dr. Huanshu Yuan, Marshall University. Synthesizes Schön (1983), Vygotsky (1978), Flavell (1979), Ladson-Billings (1995), Hammond (2015), and Zimmerman (2002) into an original theoretical model that positions structured reflection as a metacognitive tool for advancing equity in AP classrooms, particularly in Title I settings. Curriculum theory grounding in Eisner and Freire is developed separately in the CI 702 curriculum theory paper (see Appendix N).

Appendix G: Positionality Reflection

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2024). Positionality Reflection: Identity and Pedagogical Outlook. CI 704, Dr. Huanshu Yuan, Marshall University. Examines how background, identity, and professional experience shape research lens and pedagogical commitments. Grounded in Crenshaw (1989), Freire (1970), hooks (1994), Paris (2012), and Ladson-Billings (2006).

Appendix H: Annotated Bibliographies 1, 2, and 3

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2023). Annotated Bibliographies 1, 2, and 3. C-701, Dr. Sochor, Marshall University. Sustained literature review on AP equity, dual enrollment, gifted education, first-generation college students, and Black girls' postsecondary outcomes. Sources include Kyburg, Hertberg-Davis, and Callahan (2007); Saffore (2023); Dixon (2020); Snyder (2013); and Edwards, Hughes, and Weisberg (2019).

Appendix I: CIEC 700 Technology and Metacognition Paper

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2023). The Impact of Technology on Student Learning and Metacognition. CIEC 700, Marshall University. Examines smart learning environments, clicker technology, learning logs, flipped classrooms, and AI tools through a metacognitive development lens.

Appendix J: Action Research Final Presentation

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2025). Collaborative AP Classroom Use to Boost Engagement and Metacognition. Final action research presentation slide deck, Marshall University. Includes research question, methods, data visualization, and findings.

Appendix K: SITE Conference Presentation

Alexander-Blythe, M., Geddis, S., Osterfeld, B., Clemmins, T., & Rich, L. (2025). Preparing Educators for AI-Infused Classrooms. Society for Information Technology and Teacher Education Annual Conference, March 2025. Full slide deck.

Appendix L: NSSA Conference Presentation

Alexander-Blythe, M., & Childress, R. (2025). Teacher Use of Metacognitive Practices in AP Classrooms. National Social Science Association Fall Conference, Hot Springs, AR, October 2025. Presentation slides. This artifact meets the required scholarly activity for the portfolio.

Appendix M: Teaching Philosophy on Equity and Excellence in Advanced Academics

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2024). Fostering Equity and Excellence: A Teaching Philosophy for Advanced Academics. CI 704, Dr. Huanshu Yuan, Marshall University. Articulates pedagogical commitments to equitable access and instructional quality in Advanced Placement and other advanced academic contexts. Grounds the philosophy in Freire (2017) and hooks (1994), incorporates literature on AP participation and student outcomes (Chajewski, Mattern, & Shaw, 2015; Kolluri, 2011), and addresses leadership practices for narrowing opportunity gaps (Andreoli, 2023). Serves as the foundational articulation of the equity and metacognition argument that runs through the pilot study, conceptual framework, and dissertation trajectory.

Appendix N: CI 702 Curriculum Theory Paper

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2024). Curriculum as Art and Empowerment: An Integrated Framework Drawing on Eisner and Freire. CI 702, Marshall University. Synthesizes Elliot Eisner's aesthetic theory of curriculum with Paulo Freire's critical pedagogy into a personal theory of curriculum positioning advanced academics as both an artistic and political space. Engages Eisner (1985, 1994, 2002), Freire (1985, 2000), Giroux (1985, 2010), Greene (1995), Ladson-Billings (1995), McLaren (2000), Roberts (2000), and Rolling (2010). Documents the earliest articulation of the curriculum theory foundation that grounds the dissertation argument.

Appendix O: Graduate-Level AI in Education Course Modules

Alexander-Blythe, M. (2024). Graduate-level AI in education course modules: Natural Language Processing in education and student use of AI in learning. Module outlines developed for graduate course design, including overviews, learning objectives, required and optional readings, practice activities, discussion prompts, graded assignments, and evaluation criteria. Documents collaboration with faculty on graduate course development and the application of research on AI and metacognition to instructional design.